S3W1 Accessibility and Error-Handling Acceptance Criteria

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Scope

These criteria define how the Browse, Detail and Compare screens must behave when something goes wrong, and which accessibility checks each screen must pass. They extend the Sprint 2 user stories and acceptance criteria, and every criterion is written to be tested the same way by anyone.

- **Screens:** Browse (ticket list), Detail (ticket modal) and Compare.
- **Standard:** WCAG 2.1 Level AA.
- **Format:** Given / When / Then, with an ID per criterion so test scenarios and defects can point to it.
- **Assumption:** Compare shows 2 to 3 tickets the user has selected, side by side. Confirm with the team (Q-02).

Sprint 2 defects these criteria address:

Defect	Problem	Covered by
G-14	Failed load shows a raw Vercel API error with no Retry button	ERR-01 to ERR-03
G-06	Empty state wording differs and has no waitlist link	EMP-01
Sprint 2 blocker	"Missing or insufficient permissions" from Firestore	FS-01
G-10	No zone map, so no alt text	FS-04, A11Y check 1.1.1
G-04	Sold-out state not built; status must not rely on colour	A11Y check 1.4.1
G-08	Buttons about 38px	Team standard, see Q-03

Error states

Every error shows a plain-language message, offers a way forward, and never exposes technical details such as status codes, stack traces or raw API responses.

Rules for all error messages:

- Say what happened and what to do next, in one or two short sentences.
- No technical text: no error codes, "Vercel", "Firestore" or JSON.
- The rest of the page (header, navigation) keeps working.
- The message is announced to screen readers when it appears (WCAG 4.1.3).

- Technical details go to the console or logs only.

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
ERR-01	Browse	The user opens the tickets page	Ticket data fails to load (network down, server error or timeout after 10 seconds)	The message "We couldn't load tickets right now. Please try again." shows with a Retry button; no ticket cards or raw error text show
ERR-02	Browse	ERR-01's message is showing	The user selects Retry and the connection is back	A loading state shows, then the tickets load normally and the error message disappears
ERR-03	Browse	ERR-01's message is showing	Retry fails again	The same message stays, Retry still works, and the page doesn't reload or loop by itself
ERR-04	Detail	The user opens a ticket's details	That ticket's data fails to load	The modal shows "We couldn't load this ticket. Please try again." with Retry and Close buttons; focus moves to the message
ERR-05	Detail	The user opens a ticket link that no longer exists (deleted or wrong ID)	The page loads	A "Ticket not found" message shows with a "Back to tickets" link; the page doesn't crash or show a blank screen
ERR-06	Detail	The user is	Add to cart fails	The message "We

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
		viewing a ticket		couldn't add this ticket. Please try again." shows next to the button; the cart count doesn't change and the button can be pressed again
ERR-07	Detail	The user is viewing a ticket	The ticket sells out before Add to cart completes	The add fails, the button changes to "Sold out" and is disabled, and a message offers "View other tickets" (from Q-06 in Sprint 2)
ERR-08	Compare	The user has selected tickets to compare	Data for one or more tickets fails to load	The tickets that loaded still show; each failed one shows "Couldn't load this ticket" with Retry in its own column
ERR-09	Compare	The user opens a Compare link with a ticket that no longer exists	The page loads	The missing ticket is left out with a note "One ticket is no longer available"; the others still compare
ERR-10	All	Any error message is showing	A screen reader user is on the page	The message is announced without the user having to find it, and Retry or Back can be reached by keyboard

Empty states and failed Firestore reads

An empty result is not an error: it gets its own message that explains why there's nothing to show and what the user can do instead.

Empty states

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
EMP-01	Browse	Every ticket type is sold out	The user opens the tickets page	A centred message "All tickets are currently sold out. Check back later." shows with a link to join the waitlist (Q-09, Sprint 2)
EMP-02	Browse	No ticket types exist at all	The user opens the tickets page	The message "No tickets are on sale yet. Check back soon." shows; no empty cards or skeletons stay on screen
EMP-03	Browse	The user has applied a filter or search	No tickets match	"No tickets match your filters" shows with a "Clear filters" button that restores the full list
EMP-04	Compare	The user has selected no tickets	The user opens Compare	"Select 2 or 3 tickets to compare" shows with a "Browse tickets" link
EMP-05	Compare	The user has selected only 1 ticket	The user opens Compare	That ticket shows with a prompt "Add at least one more ticket to compare"
EMP-06	Detail	A ticket has no	The user opens its	The "What's not included" section

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
		exclusions	details	still shows, reading "Not specified for this ticket"

Failed Firestore reads

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
FS-01	All	Firestore rules deny access	A screen reads ticket data	The ERR-01 style message shows, not "Missing or insufficient permissions"; the real error is logged for developers
FS-02	All	Firestore takes longer than 10 seconds to respond	A screen is loading	The loading state is replaced by the ERR-01 style message with Retry
FS-03	All	The device goes offline after the page has loaded	The user does something that needs new data	"You're offline. Check your connection and try again." shows; data already on screen stays visible
FS-04	Detail	A ticket has no zone map	The user opens its details	"Zone map not available" shows in the map's place, and the seat description is still shown
FS-05	Detail	A ticket has no view description	The user opens its details	"View description coming soon" shows instead of a blank space
FS-06	Browse, Compare	A ticket is missing	The screen loads	That ticket is

ID	Screen	Given	When	Then
		a required field (name or price)		hidden, the others display normally, and the problem is logged; no "undefined", "NaN" or "$0" ever shows

WCAG 2.1 AA checks

All three screens must pass all 13 checks below before a story is marked done. "What to check" says what each check means on these screens.

ID	WCAG	Check	What to check on Browse	What to check on Detail	What to check on Compare
A11Y-01	1.1.1	Images have text alternatives	Ticket images have alt text; decorative images use empty alt	Zone map alt text says where the zone is	Any ticket images have alt text
A11Y-02	1.3.1	Structure is real markup	Page has one h1; cards use headings and lists	Modal title is a heading; Includes/Excludes are lists	Comparison is a real table with header cells
A11Y-03	1.4.1	Colour isn't the only signal	"Sold out" and "Only X left" appear as text	Price highlight also uses weight or size	Best value or differences also marked with text or icon + label
A11Y-04	1.4.3	Text contrast	All card text	All modal text, including muted sold-out text	All table text
A11Y-05	1.4.11	Non-text contrast	Buttons, card borders, focus outline	Close (X) button, Add to cart, focus outline	Remove buttons, table lines, focus outline
A11Y-06	1.4.4 / 1.4.10	Zoom and reflow	Works at 200% zoom	Modal content reachable at	Table stacks or scrolls within

ID	WCAG	Check	What to check on Browse	What to check on Detail	What to check on Compare
			and 320px wide with no sideways scrolling	200% zoom	its own area at 320px
A11Y-07	2.1.1 / 2.1.2	Keyboard only, no traps	Every button and link works with Tab, Enter and Space	Modal opens, works and closes by keyboard; Esc closes it	Add, remove and clear all work by keyboard
A11Y-08	2.4.3	Logical focus order	See pass/fail conditions	Focus moves into the modal and returns to the button that opened it	Focus follows columns left to right
A11Y-09	2.4.7	Focus is visible	Visible outline on every focused element	Same	Same
A11Y-10	2.5.3 / 4.1.2	Names and roles	Each "View details" button names its ticket	Modal has role dialog and an accessible name	Each remove button names its ticket
A11Y-11	3.3.1 / 3.3.3	Errors are identified	Error messages from ERR-01 are text, not just colour	ERR-04 and ERR-06 messages say what to do	ERR-08 says which ticket failed
A11Y-12	4.1.3	Status messages are announced	Loading, error and empty messages	Added to cart, sold out, errors	Ticket added, removed, failed
A11Y-13	2.4.2 / 3.1.1	Page title and language	Title "Tickets" plus the site name; lang="en" set	Title or heading reflects the ticket	Title "Compare tickets"

Team standard, not WCAG 2.1 AA: buttons and touch targets at least 44 by 44 px (G-08 from Sprint 2). WCAG 2.1 only requires this at level AAA, so it's tracked separately (Q-03).

Pass/fail conditions

Each check passes only if every condition in its Pass column is true on all three screens, at desktop (1440px) and mobile (375px) widths.

Contrast (A11Y-04, A11Y-05)

	Condition
Pass	Normal text (under 24px, or under 18.5px bold) is at least 4.5:1 against its background
Pass	Large text (24px or more, or 18.5px or more bold) is at least 3:1
Pass	Buttons, input borders, focus outlines and icons that carry meaning are at least 3:1 against what's next to them
Pass	Sold-out or disabled cards that still show information meet the same ratios
Fail	Any of the above is below its ratio, including hover, focus and pressed states
How to test	Lighthouse accessibility audit, then the WebAIM Contrast Checker on any colour pairs it doesn't cover (e.g. green price text, grey muted text)

Focus order (A11Y-07 to A11Y-09)

	Condition
Pass	Pressing Tab from the top of the page moves in reading order: header and navigation, then filters, then ticket cards left to right and top to bottom, then footer
Pass	Every button, link and input can be reached; nothing that can't be clicked gets focus
Pass	Opening Detail moves focus into the modal; Tab stays inside it until it closes; Esc or Close returns focus to the "View details" button that opened it
Pass	After Retry, Clear filters or removing a ticket from Compare, focus moves to a sensible place (the reloaded list, or the next ticket), not back to the top of the page

	Condition
Pass	A visible outline at least 2px thick shows on whatever has focus
Fail	Focus jumps out of order, skips an element, gets stuck, disappears or escapes an open modal
How to test	Unplug the mouse or don't touch it; Tab, Shift+Tab, Enter, Space and Esc through each screen

Labelling (A11Y-01, A11Y-10, A11Y-12)

	Condition
Pass	Every button and link has a name that makes sense on its own, e.g. "View details for Grandstand", not just "View details" repeated six times
Pass	The spoken name contains the visible label (2.5.3), so voice-control users can say what they see
Pass	Icon-only buttons (Close X, Remove) have a text label such as "Close ticket details"
Pass	Meaningful images have alt text; decorative ones have empty alt so they're skipped
Pass	Status, error and empty messages are announced when they appear
Fail	A screen reader says only "button", "image", "link" or a file name, or says nothing for a control
How to test	VoiceOver (Cmd+F5 on Mac) through each screen; Lighthouse for missing names and alt text

Open questions

ID	Question	Affects
Q-01	Is 10 seconds the right timeout before showing a loading error?	ERR-01, FS-02
Q-03	Does the team adopt 44 px as the minimum button size, even	G-08

ID	Question	Affects
	though WCAG 2.1 AA doesn't require it?	
Q-04	Should hidden tickets with missing data (FS-06) be reported somewhere the team will see, not just the console?	FS-06
Q-05	Who owns the final error and empty-state wording: design, the PO or the BA?	All ERR and EMP criteria